Artist Talk: Ryan Cockburn

Ryan Cockburn

74 Moana Street
Aramoana
Email: stereojock@yahoo.co.nz

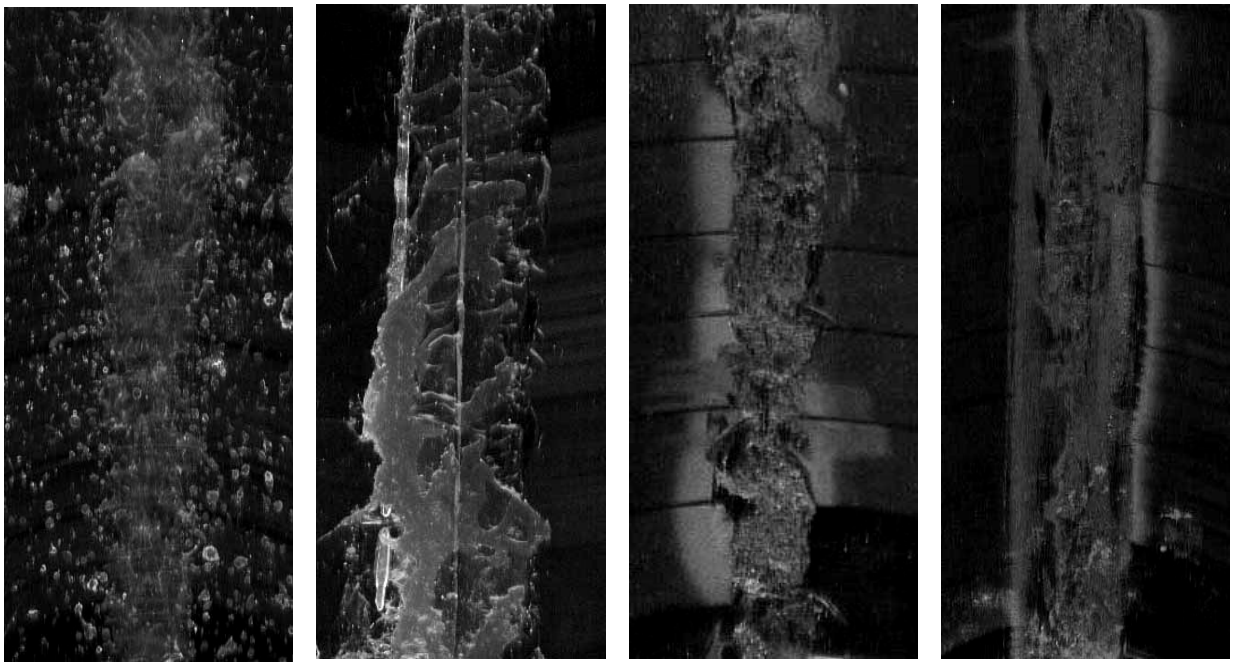
Introduction

I am in my final year of study towards the completion of my master's degree at The Otago Polytechnic School of Fine Art. My field of study is sound art, with special focus on experimental turntablism and sculptural concepts of aurality.

Before I started my master's degree, I had spent a year painting and touring around the country in a rock band. Since arriving in Dunedin, I have performed many times as a turntablist and progressed towards constructing large sculptural sound objects. My special interest in turntablism stems from a childhood fascination with the medium and as an adult I am trying to find a niche for myself in this field.

The distinctness of the turntablism I practice has it's forebears in artists such as Milan Knizak, Christian Marclay and Janek Schaefer. Unlike conventional turntablism where a mixer is employed to mix between a collection of source material, I reconstruct the records by means of cutting them in different configurations and reattaching them back together. The method of reattachment determines the playability of that particular record.

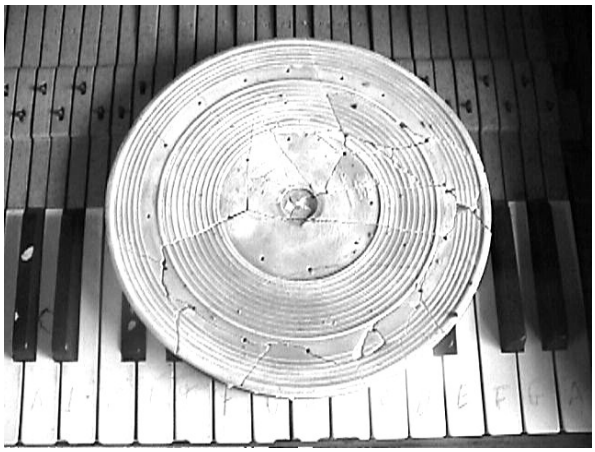
My first forays into this field involved using different things to affect the journey of the stylus across the record. I tried wax, burning the records with cigarettes, stamping on and scratching them, etc. All of these methods worked in effecting the same recording, however I wanted to construct composite records from a variety of different recordings. At first I tried a variety of bonding methods to reattach the different sides of the records back together. I tried wax and silicone sealant, which didn't bond with the vinyl record, yet created a kind of bridge between them, as seen in the illustrations below. I then began by melting the records together by means of a hot knife, smearing the remnants of other records to fill the space between, as seen below. I would then sand the join to make the record more playable, as seen below. This would affect the sound, creating a rasping sound between the two different sides.



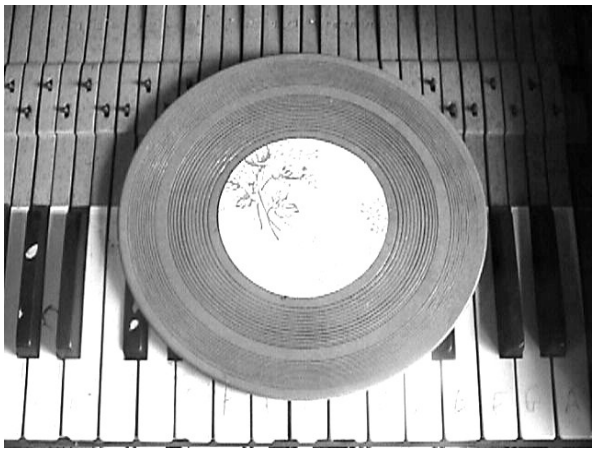
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I used and performed with these records for a period and still employ them in my performances, however I became motivated to find a cleaner way of attaching the records together so that I wouldn't have the sound of the join so prominent in the sound produced. I then discovered that I could use a vinyl glue to reattach the pieces. This led to a revolution in my work. It meant that I could now cut and glue any configuration I wanted. I then experimented with circles and the effect on the sound if I placed them within the face of the record. This along with other configurations forms the basis of the source material that I use for my sound performances when I am performing in a strictly aural sense.

I have also made my own wooden and plaster records along with many other adaptations of records that I play with during my performances. Some of these are pictured below.



This is one of the plaster records I made from a mould of the slip-pad an old gramophone unit. Below is a wooden record that I lathed cut.



Below is a piece I made by attaching a record from an old children's story book to the top of a tiny toy tambourine.



I play regularly in Dunedin and have played in Wellington in 2002 as part of the Fringe Festival. I self release recordings of my work and hope to have lathe cut records of my performances created soon. The images I have shown above are meant to be small representation of the work that goes into the sound that you will see on the audition material. I have included these images as the documentation I have provided does not show what goes in inside and on top of the turntables I use.

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